PIA2050
COMPARATIVE POLITICS & SOCIETIES

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC & INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS
SEMESTER A, A.Y. 2026/27; WEDNESDAYS, 16:00—18:50; LOCATION: YEUNG, LT-13

TEACHING STAFF

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COURSE DESCRIPTION

The course introduces students to the comparative study of politics and societies worldwide, covering themes that span two major disciplines in the "social sciences:" (i) "Political science," where "comparative politics" represents one of the largest fields of study; and (ii) "Sociology," especially the vast literature on identity and inter-group conflict. Within political science, comparative politics is defined as the study of any country's domestic politics—contrary to "international relations," which studies the relationship *between* countries, comparative politics is about what goes on *within* a country's borders, using implicit or explicit comparisons in order to develop or validate insights and generalizations of various kinds (descriptive, predictive, and explanatory or postdictive). While it is typical for introductory courses in comparative politics to follow a descriptive, country-by-country approach—focusing on the differences and similarities between the legal/constitutional structures found in different societies—this course takes a more thematic approach, exploring some of the major explanatory questions that form the subject of real-world, comparative research in the social sciences. What accounts for the failure of state- and/or nation-building processes? Why are some countries democratic, while others are still ruled by despotic, authoritarian regimes? How do political institutions develop over time? How do institutions such as the form of government, the electoral system, and federalism affect a country's political life, its stability, and its prosperity? Can certain desirable outcomes be "engineered" through the design of the right institutions? What brings people to participate in politics? Why do some societies exhibit greater levels of political protest than others? What explains the intensity of the inter-group conflicts that define a country's politics? How can the rivalry between ethnic and other identity-based groups be kept from spiraling into violence? And how does a country's politics affect its levels of economic development? These questions—and others like them—will be tackled as part of this course's wide-ranging introduction to the study of comparative politics and societies.

ASSESSMENT

The final grade for the course is determined on the basis of a student's performance on the following:

(1) Think Pieces (40%): Two brief papers or "think pieces" (two pages each) account for 40% of the final grade. The assignment questions (listed below with their deadlines) ask that students apply course materials to real-world cases. All of the essays submitted will be marked, but only the highest score will be used to calculate a student's final grade.

(2) Midterm Quiz (30%) and Final Quiz (30%): Quizzes will be held during normal class hours (in Week 7 and Week 13). Questions will deal with matters covered in class as well as a selection of the readings listed below (those highlighted in yellow).

TOPICS AND READINGS

2 September 2026
WEEK 1—What Is Comparative Politics?
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "ONE: Introducing Comparative Politics." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes: A Thematic Introduction to Comparative Politics.* University of Toronto Press.

9 September 2026
WEEK 2— Comparative Politics: Traditions of Inquiry and Theory Development
REQ./REC.: Lichbach, Mark I. and Alan S. Zuckerman (eds). 1997. *Comparative Politics: Rationality, Structure, and Culture*. Cambridge University Press. [Read: Ch.1; Rec'd: Ch. 2-4]
REC.: Elster, Jon. 2007. *Explaining Social Behavior: More Nuts and Bolts for the Social Sciences*. New York: Cambridge University Press. [Ch. 1-5, 7-9, 11-12, 15, 18-19, 23-24]

16 September 2026
WEEK 3—The Engine of History: Identity and the Dynamics of Inter-Group Conflict
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "TWO: Development and Political Development." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes.* University of Toronto Press.
REQ.: Fukuyama, Francis. 1992. *The End of History and the Last Man*. New York: The Free Press. [Ch. 11-12]
REC.: Tajfel, Henri and John C. Turner. 1986. "The Social Identity Theory of Inter-Group Behavior." In S. Worchel and L.W. Austin (eds.), *Psychology of Intergroup Relations.* Chicago: Nelson-Hall.

23 September 2026
WEEK 4—A World of "Nation-States:" The Study of State- and Nation-Building Processes
REQ.: Fukuyama, Francis. 2014. *Political Order and Political Decay: From the Industrial Revolution to the Globalization of Democracy.* New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux. [Introduction]
REQ./REC.: Anderson, Benedict. 1991[1983]. *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism*. London: Verso. [Read: Ch. 1; Rec'd: Ch. 2-7]
REC.: Fukuyama, Francis. 2011. *The Origins of Political Order: From Prehuman Times to the French Revolution*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux. [Ch. 1-9].

30 September 2026
WEEK 5— Democracy, Non-Democracy, and Pseudo-Democracy: A Taxonomy of Regime Types
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "FOUR: Electoral Democracies, Liberal Democracies, and Autocracies." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes.* University of Toronto Press.
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "EIGHT: Varieties of Autocracies: Totalitarianism, Sultanism, and Authoritarianism." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes.* University of Toronto Press.
REC.: Schmitter, Philippe C. and Terry Lynn Karl. 1991. "What Democracy Is… and Is Not." *Journal of Democracy* 2: 75-88.

7 October 2026
WEEK 6— From Democracy to Dictatorship and Back: Democratic Transitions and Authoritarian Reversals
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "FIVE: Factors Conducive to Democracy." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes.* University of Toronto Press.
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2013. "NINE: Democratic Transitions, Consolidations, and Breakdowns." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes.* University of Toronto Press.

THINK PIECE DEADLINE: *Choose a country located outside Western Europe and North America that regularly holds legislative elections. Comment on whether this country should, or should not, be classified as a democracy.*

14 October 2026
WEEK 7—MIDTERM QUIZ

21 October 2026
WEEK 8—Designing Political Institutions, Part I: Presidents and Assemblies
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "SIX: Institutional Variations of Democracies." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes*. University of Toronto Press.
REC.: Sartori, Giovanni. 1994. *Comparative Constitutional Engineering: An Inquiry into Structures, Incentives, and Outcomes*. Palgrave-MacMillan UK. [Rec'd: Part II]

28 October 2026
WEEK 9—Designing Political Institutions, Part II: Political Parties, Elections, and Electoral Systems
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "SEVEN: Electoral Systems, Party Systems, and Government Formation in Democracies." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes*. University of Toronto Press.
REC.: Sartori, Giovanni. 1997. *Comparative Constitutional Engineering: An Inquiry into Structures, Incentives, and Outcomes*. Palgrave-MacMillan UK. [Rec'd: Part I]

4 November 2026
WEEK 10—Designing Political Institutions, Part III: Federal and Unitary Governments
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "SIX: Institutional Variations of Democracies." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes*. University of Toronto Press.
REC.: Chandra, Kanchan. 2005. "Ethnic Parties and Democratic Stability." *Perspectives on Politics* 3: 235-252.

11 November 2026
WEEK 11—The Causes of the Wealth of Nations: Jared Diamond's *Guns, Germs, and Steel*
REQ.: Diamond, Jared. 1999. *Guns, Germs, and Steel: The Fates of Human Societies*. New York: W.W. Norton & Co. [Read: "Prologue: Yali's Question" and "Epilogue: The Future of Human History as a Science"]

THINK PIECE DEADLINE: *Choose a country located outside Western Europe and North America that holds regular and fairly competitive elections. Formulate an institutional reform proposal designed to improve the stability or the quality of government.*

18 November 2026
WEEK 12—Political Institutions and the Economy: (Non-)Democracy and (Under-)Development
REQ.: Siaroff, Alan. 2022. "THREE: State Effectiveness and Political Economy." In A. Siaroff, *Comparing Political Regimes*. University of Toronto Press.
REC.: Przeworski, Adam and Fernando Limongi. 1993. "Political Regimes and Economic Growth." *The Journal of Economic Perspectives* 7: 51-69
REC.: Przeworski, Adam and Fernando Limongi. 1997. "Modernization: Theories and Facts." *World Politics* 49: 155-83.

25 November 2026
WEEK 13—FINAL QUIZ

ACADEMIC HONESTY

Rules on academic honesty: https://www.cityu.edu.hk/pvdp/ah/ah-rules.htm
Online tutorial on academic honesty: https://www.cityu.edu.hk/ah/
Guidelines on use of Generative AI tools: https://www.cityu.edu.hk/GenAI/guidelines.htm
PIA Head's letter concerning academic honesty: Read on Canvas (click on the "Files" tab)